GUIDELINES TO WRITING THESIS

A thesis is typically composed of a number of sections:

- Abstract
- Introduction
- Materials & methods
- Results & discussion
- Conclusions & recommendations
- References

1. Abstract

An abstract is a brief summary (of specified word limit) of the content of the manuscript. It should provide the highlights from the introduction, methods, results, discussion and conclusions. It must make sense when read in isolation for those who read only the abstract. An abstract must not contain data which are not included in the results.

2. Introduction

The purpose of the introduction is to stimulate the reader's interest and to provide background information which is pertinent to the study. Background to the topic (past verb tense)

- Background of study
- Problem statement
- Importance & significant of study
- Aims & objectives

3. Methods

This section is descriptive. The main consideration is to ensure that enough detail is provided to verify the findings and to enable replication of the study. Information should be presented, using the past verb tense, in chronological order.

- Materials

- Equipment, instruments or measurement tools

- Procedures

- Detailed description, in chronological order, of exactly what was done and by whom.
- Method of calculating derived variables, dealing with outlying values and missing data.
- Methods used to summarize data (present verb tense)

4. Results

The two functions of this section are to report the results (past verb tense) of the procedures described in the methods and to present the evidence that is the data (in the form of text, tables or figures), that supports the results. Results and discussion can be combined into one section.

Tables and figures (photographs, drawings, graphs, and flow diagrams) are often used to present details whereas the narrative section of the results tends to be used to present the general findings.

5. Discussion

The discussion should serves to answer the question(s) posed in the introduction, explain how the results support the answers and how the answers fit in with existing knowledge on the topic. This is the main section in which the author can express his/her interpretations and opinions.

6. Conclusions

This section should comprise a brief statement of the major findings and implications of the study. It is not the function of this section to summarize the study; this is the purpose of the abstract. New information must not be included in the conclusions.

7. Reference

Example:

Jenkins S 1995 How to write a paper for a scientific journal. Australian Journal of Physiotherapy 41(4): 285 – 289.